

5 Whys Analysis – Post-Discharge Follow-Up Failure

Problem Statement: Patients are missing their first post-discharge follow-up appointment within 7 days, leading to gaps in continuity of care.

5 Whys Questions:

Why 1 Can you walk me through what happens from the moment a patient is discharged to when their first follow-up appointment is scheduled and confirmed?

Why 2 How is responsibility for scheduling and confirming the follow-up appointment assigned between inpatient and outpatient teams?

Why 3 What processes are currently in place to ensure that follow-up appointments are scheduled before or immediately after discharge?

Why 4 Are there any systems, alerts, or dashboards that track whether a patient has missed or not scheduled their follow-up appointment?

Why 5 How do different systems (inpatient, outpatient, and EHR) communicate with each other to support real-time coordination and visibility into patient follow-up status?

Bonus Why 6 What challenges or constraints prevent these processes from being automated or standardized across the care system?

Reflection These questions are designed to uncover gaps in workflow, ownership, and system integration, and would help guide a deeper conversation with stakeholders to identify root causes.